

Title PL False Narrative That Polish Court Legalized Taking Down Foreign Flags 04/06/2025

Summary

- Pro-Russian activist Marcin Bustowski falsely claimed that a Polish court had legalized the removal of foreign flags, sparking a coordinated disinformation campaign amplified by AI-generated content and pro-Kremlin actors. This narrative, widely spread on social media and fringe websites, incited criminal acts and directly led to the removal of foreign flags from public buildings in Gdańsk and Racibórz.
- The main narrative was that foreign symbols, particularly Ukrainian flags, are unlawfully imposed in Poland and can be legally removed by citizens.
- The disinformation campaign reached over 1.5 million views across X and Facebook, resulting in real-life incidents including the removal of the Ukrainian flag from Gdańsk City Hall and the German flag from a school polling station in Racibórz.
- Prompting symbolic actions, while pro-Russian websites amplified the narrative and social media spread disinformation in an information void lacking clear official corrections.
- On May 30, the case was reported to NASK, 57 posts were flagged to META (which refused to remove them), five videos were reported to TikTok (the main one removed 13 minutes after reporting), and recommended actions include launching an awareness campaign about the illegality of such acts and targeted social education.

Incident

Marcin Bustowski (leader of the pro-Russian party 'Przebudzeni Konsumenci' ['Awaken Consumers']) on 29.05.2025 at 19:08 published a [video](#) in which he stated that the appeal court in Wrocław had issued a ruling legalizing removing foreign flags from the official buildings. That day Bustowski appealed against the verdict from 2024, when he was convicted of insulting the Ukrainian flag. Bustowski is a pro-Russian activist, he [spreads](#) pro-Russian and anti-Semitic propaganda, is [associated](#) with the Konfederacja party and the pro-Russian organisation 'Kamraci'. The next day on his YouTube channel he [reinforced](#) false claims about legalization of removing foreign flags.

This statement is false, since the court of appeal did not legalise the removal of foreign flags - it is a criminal offence under [Article 137\(2\)](#) of the Criminal Code. The appeal court did not overturn the verdict in Bustowski's case, but only changed the fine to a two-year suspended sentence.

On the night of May 30 at 02:13 user @robercki_40 published the video on TikTok (already removed) and [Facebook](#), in which he urged so-called 'patriots' and 'wolves' to tear down foreign (especially Ukrainian) flags from public office buildings. The video uses AI generated images and voice over. The creator is [Robert Rychtik](#), digital creator, who produces materials with anti-systemic, anti-immigrant, and anti-LGBTQ. The false claim was [amplified](#) as well by another pro-Kremlin actor, Paweł Dankiewicz, associated with the pro-Russian [organisation](#) 'Nowa Polska ponad podziałami' ('New Poland Beyond Divisions'). The social media posts incite people to commit a crime under Article 137(2) of the Criminal Code and mislead them into believing that it has been legalised.

The false message about legality of taking down Ukrainian flags was massively amplified on social media platforms (especially Facebook and X). Also, this statement was amplified by websites like [legaartis\[.pl\]](#) (pretending to be a legal advisory firm) or [magnapolonia\[.org\]](#) that, according to the government Commission for the Investigation of Russian and Belarusian Influence, are part of a [pro-Russian network](#) operating in Poland. On Saturday, May 31 at around 8:50, two men [removed](#) the Ukrainian flag from the Gdańsk City Hall building and handed it over to municipal employees. The men claimed that they were acting legally and referred to a supposed ruling by the Wrocław Court of Appeal on Friday, 29 May. The matter was reported to the police, and the flag was hung back up. On 1 June, Michał Woś, a member of the Law and Justice party, [removed](#) the German flag from a school in Racibórz where a polling station was located.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Foreign symbols, especially Ukrainian flags, are unlawfully imposed in Poland and citizens have a legal and patriotic right to remove them.

Sub-narratives: Polish courts support the right to remove foreign flags; Ukrainian (and other foreign) symbols are a threat to Polish national identity and/or should be removed; Citizens must act on their own and take justice

in their own hands.

Impact

Reach: X: 7,460 posts, shared by 5,290 users, with a total of 1,500,000 views (one [video](#) has 451,100 views); Facebook: at least 600 hundred posts published on May 29, one [video](#) has 305,000 views.

Outcome: removal of the Ukrainian flag from the city hall in Gdańsk (31 May 2025), removal of the German flag from a school in Racibórz, where a polling station was located (1 June 2025).

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0138.001: Encourage](#) - encourage people to take down foreign flags from public buildings.

[T0042: Seed Kernel of Truth](#) - information about the appeal court ruling was misleading.

[T0057.002: Conduct Symbolic Action](#) - Ukrainian and German flags were taken down after the disinformation.

[T0049.007: Inauthentic Sites Amplify News and Narratives](#) - Polish pro-Russian websites amplified the false information.

[T0049.008: Generate Information Pollution](#) - social media promoted false information that taking down foreign flags was legalized, there was no official disclaimer easily accessible, there was information void exploited by the malign actors.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: On May 30 at 15:15 case was reported to NASK, the same day 57 posts were reported to META (which refused to remove 40 posts, did not respond to 17), 5 videos reported to TikTok (main one video reported on May 30 at 16:26, removed 13 minutes later).

Recommendations: Conducting an awareness campaign that these actions are illegal and may lead to criminal offences. Social education with the help of influencers who have an audience in nationalist and anti-Ukrainian circles.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
NA	Russia, etc.	Upon request	Jakub Kubś, GLOBSEC	Facebook, TikTok.	X,